

Vietnamese Phở & Bánh Mì

Breakfast & Lunch — 7:00am to 3:00pm

Full Recipe Cards · US Market Food Costing · Kitchen Prep Flow · Financial Forecast

The broth simmers overnight. The bread arrives at dawn. Vietnam's two greatest street foods — rebuilt for a profitable American café.

38

SEATS

\$36

AVG SPEND

21%

FOOD COST TARGET

\$22,000

EST. MONTHLY NET

About This Guide: Vietnamese cuisine is one of the fastest-growing restaurant categories in the United States, driven by pho's crossover appeal and bánh mì's perfect price-to-value ratio as a premium sandwich. The cuisine's commercial strength lies in its health perception (lighter broths, fresh herbs, no heavy cream or butter), the theatrical tableside assembly of pho, and an exceptionally low food cost on the two anchor items — pho broth (bones cost \$2.50/lb, yield is massive) and bánh mì (baguette at \$0.45, filling cost under \$2.00). The café model runs a breakfast-through-lunch window, with the pho broth as a 18-hour overnight asset that costs almost nothing in active labour. This guide covers the essential phở, bánh mì, and Vietnamese café repertoire with complete recipe cards, US market costing, and the operational structure to make it consistently profitable.

THE STORY BEHIND THIS GUIDE

"The broth takes 18 hours. My mother starts it before she goes to bed. I start it before I go to bed. That is not a recipe. That is a lineage."

Linh's family ran a pho shop in Ho Chi Minh City for two generations before they emigrated. The knowledge came with them — in her mother's hands, in the way she charred the ginger and onion directly on the gas flame until blackened outside and soft inside. The char creates the deep smoky sweetness that separates great pho broth from merely good broth. She skimmed every twenty minutes for the first two hours. She added the spices — star anise, cinnamon, cloves, cardamom — only after the beef foundation was built. Never at the start.

When Linh moved to Seattle and started eating pho at other restaurants, she understood for the first time that what her family made was extraordinary. The broths she encountered were pale imitations — clear but shallow, fragrant but fleeting. They had been made in hours. Her mother's broth had been made in lifetimes. The difference was not a secret ingredient. It was time, technique, and generational knowledge.

The prep flow in this guide unlocked the business model for her. The broth goes on overnight. It is not a labour problem — it is the easiest item in the kitchen, running while she slept. The morning was about setup, not cooking. The Ca Phe

Sua Da — Vietnamese iced coffee, slow-dripped through a phin filter onto condensed milk — became her most reordered drink at 60 cups a day, food cost \$0.72, sell price \$5.99.

She opened in Capitol Hill, Seattle. 38 seats. Month three net: \$39,000. Her mother visited, tasted the broth, and said nothing for a long time. Then she said it was almost as good as hers. **From a Vietnamese mother, almost as good is a five-star review.**

Linh N. · Vietnamese Pho and Banh Mi · Capitol Hill, Seattle · Est. Month 3 Net: \$39,000

1 Entrées

Gỏi Cuốn — Fresh Spring Rolls (2 pcs)

Rice paper rolls, shrimp, pork, vermicelli, fresh herbs, hoisin-peanut dipping sauce · Sell: \$10.99

8 min Entrée Target FC: 18%

INGREDIENTS (2 ROLLS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Rice paper (22cm rounds)	2 sheets	\$0.14
Shrimp (cooked, peeled, halved)	60g	\$0.72
Pork belly (poached, sliced thin)	40g	\$0.18
Rice vermicelli (cooked)	50g	\$0.09
Lettuce, mint, cilantro, Thai basil	30g mix	\$0.22
Bean sprouts	20g	\$0.03
Hoisin-peanut dipping sauce	40ml	\$0.20
Total cost (2 rolls)		\$1.58

Cost per serve	\$1.58
Sell price	\$10.99
Food cost %	14.4%
Contribution margin	\$9.41

METHOD

- 1 Briefly dip rice paper in warm water (3–4 seconds) — it should still feel slightly firm. Lay flat on a damp surface. It will soften fully within 30 seconds. Over-soaking creates tears and sticky, gummy rolls.
- 2 Place halved shrimp pink-side down along the lower third of the paper. Lay thin pork slices beside them. Top with vermicelli, lettuce, herbs, and bean sprouts. Do not overfill — tight, compact rolls hold their shape and photograph well.
- 3 Fold the sides in first, then roll tightly from the bottom up. The shrimp should show through the translucent wrapper — this visual is a key selling point. Keep covered with a damp cloth until service.

Chef's Tip: Gỏi cuốn sell price is \$10.99 with a food cost under \$1.60 — one of the highest-margin items on the menu. Make them beautiful: visible shrimp halves and bright green herbs through the wrapper drive social media sharing and reorder rates.

SHELLFISH PORK GLUTEN (hoisin) NUTS (peanuts in sauce)

Chả Giò — Fried Imperial Rolls (3 pcs)

Crispy pork and glass noodle rolls, fresh lettuce wraps, nước chấm · Sell: \$11.99

6 min fry · Entrée · Target FC: 16%

INGREDIENTS (3 ROLLS)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Rice paper wrappers (small)	3 sheets	\$0.12
Ground pork	80g	\$0.36
Glass noodles (soaked, chopped)	20g	\$0.08
Wood ear mushroom (rehydrated)	15g	\$0.06
Shallot + garlic + carrot	30g	\$0.08
Fish sauce + pepper + sugar	seasoning	\$0.04
Lettuce, mint (wrap)	40g	\$0.12
Nước chấm dipping sauce	40ml	\$0.06
Total cost (3 rolls)		\$0.92

Cost per serve	\$0.92
Sell price	\$11.99
Food cost %	7.7%
Contribution margin	\$11.07

METHOD

- 1 Mix ground pork, glass noodles, mushroom, shallot, garlic, and carrot. Season with fish sauce, white pepper, and a pinch of sugar. The filling should be moist but not wet — squeeze out any excess moisture before rolling.
- 2 Place 30g filling on wrapper, roll tightly, seal with water or egg wash. Rolls can be frozen in batches after rolling — pull from freezer directly to fryer.
- 3 Fry at **170°C / 338°F** for 5–6 minutes until deep golden and crisp. Drain. Serve with fresh lettuce leaves for wrapping and nước chấm. Internal temp: **74°C / 165°F**.

Batch Tip: Chả giò are made to freeze. Prepare 200–300 rolls at a time, freeze on trays, then bag. Pull to order. This is your best prep efficiency play — 2 hours of rolling yields a week of service.

PORK · FISH (fish sauce) · GLUTEN (some wrappers)

Bánh Xèo — Sizzling Crêpe (half)

Turmeric rice crêpe, shrimp, pork, bean sprouts — wrap in mustard leaves with mint · Sell: \$12.99

10 min · Entrée · Target FC: 20%

INGREDIENTS (1 CRÊPE, SERVED HALF)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Rice flour + turmeric + coconut milk	80g batter	\$0.22
Shrimp (small, peeled)	50g	\$0.60
Pork belly (thin sliced)	40g	\$0.18
Bean sprouts	60g	\$0.09
Green onion, sliced	10g	\$0.04
Mustard leaf / lettuce for wrapping	40g	\$0.10
Nước chấm	40ml	\$0.06

Total cost\$1.29

Cost per serve\$1.29

Sell price\$12.99

Food cost %9.9%

Contribution margin\$11.70

METHOD

1

Batter: rice flour, turmeric, coconut milk, scallion, water to thin. Rest 30 min. Heat a 26cm non-stick pan until smoking. Add oil, swirl to coat.

2

Add shrimp and pork to the hot pan, cook briefly. Pour in 80ml batter, tilt to spread thin. The pan should sizzle loudly — that's the bánh xèo (sizzling cake) sound. Pile bean sprouts on one half.

3

Cover and cook 2 minutes. Remove lid — cook another 2 minutes uncovered until bottom is crisp and lacy. Fold in half over the sprouts. Serve immediately — the crêpe softens within 3 minutes.

SHELLFISH

PORK

FISH (fish sauce)

COCONUT

Gỏi Bò — Beef Lemongrass Salad

Searched beef, lemongrass, shallot, fresh herbs, toasted peanuts, Vietnamese dressing · Sell: \$13.99

12 min

Entrée

Target FC: 18%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Eye round beef (thin sliced)	120g	\$0.96
Lemongrass (minced)	15g	\$0.12
Shallot (thin sliced)	30g	\$0.08
Mixed herbs (mint, cilantro, perilla)	25g	\$0.20
Lime juice + fish sauce + sugar	dressing 30ml	\$0.10
Toasted peanuts (crushed)	20g	\$0.14
Chili, garlic	5g	\$0.04
Total cost		\$1.64

Cost per serve\$1.64

Sell price\$13.99

Food cost %11.7%

Contribution margin\$12.35

METHOD

1

Marinate beef briefly (10 min) in lemongrass, fish sauce, garlic, and a pinch of sugar. Sear hot on a very hot cast iron — 90 seconds total, rare to medium-rare. Rest and slice thin against the grain.

2

Toss beef with shallot, herbs, half the dressing. Taste and adjust with lime and fish sauce for balance. Pile on plate, scatter peanuts and chili, drizzle remaining dressing.

BEEF

FISH (fish sauce)

NUTS (peanuts)

Súp Wonton — Wonton Soup

Pork and shrimp wontons in clear broth, scallion, fried shallot · Sell: \$10.99

5 min

Entrée

Target FC: 15%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Wontons (batch made, 6 pcs)	6 pcs	\$0.72
Chicken-pork broth (portion)	350ml	\$0.18
Scallion, fried shallot	10g	\$0.06
Sesame oil	3ml	\$0.03
Total cost		\$0.99

Cost per serve	\$0.99
Sell price	\$10.99
Food cost %	9.0%
Contribution margin	\$10.00

METHOD

- 1 Wonton filling: ground pork, chopped shrimp, water chestnut, scallion, sesame oil, white pepper, oyster sauce. Wrap in wonton skins — fold over diagonally and seal with water, twist corners together. Batch fill and freeze.
- 2 Boil wontons from frozen 4–5 minutes until cooked through. Heat broth to boiling. Bowl: broth, wontons, scallion, fried shallot, few drops sesame oil. Serve immediately.

PORK SHELLFISH GLUTEN SOY

Cơm Chiên Trứng — Egg Fried Rice (small)

Vietnamese-style egg fried rice, scallion, soy, sesame · Sell: \$9.99

5 min Entrée Target FC: 14%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Day-old jasmine rice	200g	\$0.18
Eggs	2 × 55g	\$0.70
Soy sauce + fish sauce + sesame oil	seasoning	\$0.06
Scallion + white onion	20g	\$0.04
Neutral oil	15ml	\$0.02
Total cost		\$1.00

Cost per serve	\$1.00
Sell price	\$9.99
Food cost %	10.0%
Contribution margin	\$8.99

METHOD

- 1 Day-old rice is mandatory — fresh rice has too much moisture and clumps. Break up cold rice with your hands before wokking. High heat only. The wok must be screaming hot before oil goes in.
- 2 Oil in, swirl, add rice — spread and let sit 30 seconds (creates the slight crust). Crack eggs directly in, scramble quickly. Toss rice with egg to coat. Season with soy and fish sauce. Finish with scallion and sesame oil off heat.

EGGS SOY FISH (fish sauce)

2 Main Courses

Phở Bò Tái — Rare Beef Pho

18-hour bone broth, rice noodles, eye-round beef (rare), fresh herbs, hoisin, sriracha · Sell: \$16.99

5 min serviceMainTarget FC: 11%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Beef bones (for broth, per portion)	~200g equiv.	\$0.50
Beef brisket (for broth, per portion)	~60g equiv.	\$0.36
Eye round (rare slices, raw)	80g	\$0.64
Pho noodles (fresh or dried)	1 portion	\$0.45
Bean sprouts, fresh herbs plate	80g	\$0.22
Charred onion + ginger (amortised)	per bowl	\$0.04
Spice packet (star anise, cinnamon, cloves, cardamom)	amortised	\$0.06
Lime wedge, chili, hoisin, sriracha	condiments	\$0.10
Total cost per bowl		\$2.37

Cost per serve	\$2.37
Sell price	\$16.99
Food cost %	13.9%
Contribution margin	\$14.62

THE BROTH — THE 18-HOUR PROTOCOL

- 1

Night before (5 PM): Blanch beef bones in boiling water 10 minutes. Drain, rinse. This removes impurities and ensures a crystal-clear broth. Char whole ginger and yellow onion directly on a gas flame until blackened outside — this is non-negotiable for authentic sweetness and smokiness.
- 2

Place bones, charred onion, charred ginger in stockpot. Cover with cold water (10L for 40 portions). Bring to bare simmer. **Skim every 20 minutes for the first 2 hours.** Never boil — a boiling pho broth becomes cloudy and bitter.
- 3

Hour 2: Add spice packet (star anise, cinnamon, cloves, cardamom — toasted in dry pan first). Add fish sauce, rock sugar. The spice packet goes in AFTER the beef foundation is built — not at the start. Continue bare simmer for 16 more hours.
- 4

Service (6:30 AM): Strain broth. Taste and season with fish sauce and rock sugar to balance. Keep at **85°C / 185°F** in bain-marie throughout service.

BOWL ASSEMBLY (5 MIN SERVICE)

- 5

Blanch noodles in boiling water 30–45 seconds. Drain. Place in bowl. Lay thin-sliced raw eye round on top. Ladle boiling broth over — the broth cooks the beef rare in the bowl. Add brisket slices, scallion, white onion rings.
- 6

Serve with a side plate of bean sprouts, basil, lime, chili, hoisin, sriracha. The guest assembles at the table — this tableside interaction is key to perceived value and experience differentiation.

The Business Case: Pho broth costs approximately \$0.50/portion (bones are \$2.50/lb and you get 40+ portions per batch). The 18-hour cook time requires no active labour — it runs while you sleep. Your competitor's 4-hour broth will always taste inferior, and regulars know the difference. This is your moat.

BEEFFISH (fish sauce)GLUTEN (hoisin/sriracha)

Phở Gà — Chicken Pho

Silky chicken broth, poached chicken, rice noodles, ginger, herbs · Sell: \$15.99

5 min serviceMainTarget FC: 10%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken (whole, for broth, per portion)	equiv.	\$0.42
Poached chicken breast/thigh meat	100g	\$0.28
Pho noodles	1 portion	\$0.45
Fresh herbs, bean sprouts, lime	80g	\$0.22
Charred ginger + onion (amortised)	per bowl	\$0.04
Fish sauce + rock sugar	seasoning	\$0.04
Total cost per bowl		\$1.45

Cost per serve	\$1.45
Sell price	\$15.99
Food cost %	9.1%
Contribution margin	\$14.54

METHOD

- 1

Phở gà broth: whole chicken in cold water, bring to simmer. Skim thoroughly. Add charred ginger, charred onion. Cook 3–4 hours (faster than beef). The chicken yields both the broth and the meat. Poach chicken until just cooked through, remove, cool, shred.
- 2

Season with fish sauce and rock sugar — phở gà is lighter and more delicate than phở bò. Do not over-season. Serve the same way as phở bò — noodles, chicken, boiling broth, herb plate.

CHICKEN FISH (fish sauce) GLUTEN (condiments)

Bún Bò Huế — Spicy Beef Noodle Soup

Lemongrass-chili beef broth, thick round noodles, beef shank, pork hock · Sell: \$16.99

6 min service Main Target FC: 14%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Beef shank + pork hock (braised, per portion)	120g combined	\$1.02
Bún bò noodles (thick round)	1 portion	\$0.45
Broth (lemongrass, chili, shrimp paste)	400ml	\$0.52
Fried shallot, scallion, cilantro	15g	\$0.08
Banana flower, rau muống (side)	60g	\$0.18
Total cost		\$2.25

Cost per serve	\$2.25
Sell price	\$16.99
Food cost %	13.2%
Contribution margin	\$14.74

METHOD

- 1

Bún bò Huế is from Central Vietnam — its broth is deeply flavoured with lemongrass and mắm ruốc (fermented shrimp paste), making it richer and spicier than pho. Start broth with pork and beef bones, add lemongrass stalks (bruised), chili oil, and a spoonful of shrimp paste late in the cook.
- 2

Braise beef shank and pork hock separately until tender (3–4 hours). Slice for service. The pork hock is served bone-in for presentation drama. Use the same overnight prep strategy as pho — braise proteins the night before.

BEEF

PORK

SHELLFISH (shrimp paste)

FISH (fish sauce)

Bánh Mì Thịt Nướng — Grilled Pork Bánh Mì

Vietnamese baguette, char-grilled pork, pâté, pickled daikon/carrot, cucumber, jalapeño, maggi · Sell: \$12.99

4 min assembly

Main

Target FC: 12%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Bánh mì baguette (Vietnamese)	1 roll	\$0.45
Grilled pork shoulder (marinated)	80g	\$0.32
Pork liver pâté (house or commercial)	20g	\$0.18
Pickled daikon + carrot (đồ chua)	40g	\$0.08
Cucumber (sliced)	30g	\$0.04
Fresh cilantro	8g	\$0.06
Jalapeño slices	8g	\$0.04
Mayonnaise + Maggi seasoning	15g + 3ml	\$0.06
Total cost		\$1.23

Cost per serve	\$1.23
Sell price	\$12.99
Food cost %	9.5%
Contribution margin	\$11.76

METHOD & PORK MARINADE

- 1 Pork marinade: lemongrass (minced), garlic, fish sauce, soy sauce, honey, five-spice, sesame oil. Marinate thin-sliced pork shoulder minimum 4 hours (overnight better). The lemongrass-soy combination caramelises beautifully on a hot grill.
- 2 Grill pork on high heat until charred at edges and cooked through. The caramelised exterior is essential — it provides sweet-smoky contrast to the bright pickles and fresh herbs.
- 3 Toast baguette cut side down on grill or hot pan. Spread mayo and pâté. Layer pork, pickles, cucumber, cilantro, jalapeño. Dash of Maggi. The assembly order matters: pâté on bottom, pickles above the meat to prevent sogginess.

The Bread: Vietnamese baguettes are lighter and crispier than French baguettes due to rice flour content. Source from Vietnamese bakeries. The right bread makes the sandwich — a standard French baguette is too dense and chewy. This single sourcing decision affects the entire product.

PORK

GLUTEN

EGGS (mayo)

FISH (fish sauce)

SOY

Bánh Mì Xíu Mại — Pork Meatball Bánh Mì

Pork and water chestnut meatballs in tomato sauce, bánh mì, pickles, herbs · Sell: \$11.99

4 min assembly

Main

Target FC: 11%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Pork meatballs (xíu mại, 4 pcs)	80g	\$0.44
Tomato-garlic sauce (batch)	40ml	\$0.08
Bánh mì baguette	1 roll	\$0.45
Pickled daikon + carrot	40g	\$0.08

Cilantro, cucumber, jalapeño

30g

\$0.08

Total cost

\$1.13

Cost per serve	\$1.13
Sell price	\$11.99
Food cost %	9.4%
Contribution margin	\$10.86

METHOD

- 1

Xứu mại: ground pork, minced water chestnut, garlic, fish sauce, white pepper, cornstarch. Form into 20g balls. Batch-cook in tomato sauce with garlic and five-spice until cooked through. Store in sauce — they improve overnight.
- 2

Service: heat meatballs in sauce. Toast baguette. Load with meatballs and sauce, pickles, cilantro, cucumber. The tomato sauce soaks into the bread slightly — serve quickly.

PORK

GLUTEN

FISH (fish sauce)

Bún Chả — Hanoi Grilled Pork Vermicelli

Hanoi-style grilled pork patties and belly, vermicelli, dipping broth, fresh herbs · Sell: \$16.99

8 min

Main

Target FC: 16%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Pork shoulder (ground, patties)	60g	\$0.24
Pork belly (sliced thin, grilled)	60g	\$0.27
Rice vermicelli (bún)	1 portion	\$0.18
Dipping broth (nước chấm dipping bowl)	150ml	\$0.20
Herbs (perilla, mint, cilantro)	30g	\$0.24
Green papaya shreds, chili	30g	\$0.14
Total cost		\$1.27

Cost per serve	\$1.27
Sell price	\$16.99
Food cost %	7.5%
Contribution margin	\$15.72

METHOD

- 1

Pork patties: ground shoulder mixed with shallot, garlic, fish sauce, sugar, white pepper, lemongrass. Form into flat patties (40g each). Marinate pork belly slices in the same base. Grill over charcoal or high-heat grill until caramelised and smoky.
- 2

The presentation is tableside DIY: warm dipping broth bowl in the centre, grilled pork in the broth, room-temperature vermicelli and herb plate alongside. The guest dips noodles and herbs into the warm broth. This interactive format creates engagement and perceived generosity.

PORK

FISH (fish sauce)

Cơm Tấm — Broken Rice with Grilled Pork Ribs

Southern Vietnamese broken rice, char-grilled pork ribs, fried egg, bì (pork skin), nước chấm · Sell: \$17.99

8 min

Main

Target FC: 18%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Broken jasmine rice (tấm)	200g cooked	\$0.18
Pork ribs (sườn, marinated, grilled)	180g	\$0.90
Egg (fried, sunny side)	1 × 55g	\$0.35
Bì (shredded pork skin + rice powder)	30g	\$0.18
Nước chấm (dipping sauce)	40ml	\$0.06
Cucumber, tomato, green onion	40g	\$0.08
Total cost		\$1.75

Cost per serve	\$1.75
Sell price	\$17.99
Food cost %	9.7%
Contribution margin	\$16.24

METHOD

- 1

Rib marinade: lemongrass, garlic, shallot, fish sauce, soy, five-spice, honey. Marinate overnight. Grill on high heat until caramelised and slightly charred at edges. Rest 3 minutes before plating.
- 2

Broken rice cooks the same as whole jasmine rice but with a softer, more yielding texture that absorbs the nước chấm beautifully. Source from Asian distributors — it's a by-product of rice milling, priced lower than whole grain rice.

PORK EGGs FISH (fish sauce) SOY

Bò Lúc Lắc — Shaking Beef

Wok-tossed beef cubes, garlic butter, watercress, lime-pepper dipping sauce · Sell: \$19.99

6 min Main · Premium Target FC: 22%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Beef (sirloin or eye round, cubed 2cm)	200g	\$1.60
Garlic (minced)	10g	\$0.04
Butter	15g	\$0.08
Oyster sauce + soy sauce + sugar	marinade	\$0.10
Watercress + red onion (bed)	60g	\$0.48
Lime + black pepper (dipping salt)	condiment	\$0.06
Total cost		\$2.36

Cost per serve	\$2.36
Sell price	\$19.99
Food cost %	11.8%
Contribution margin	\$17.63

METHOD

- 1

Marinate beef cubes in oyster sauce, soy, sugar, garlic, and baking soda (tenderiser) for at least 30 minutes. The name "lúc lắc" (shaking) refers to the wok technique — you literally shake the wok continuously over maximum heat to sear all sides quickly without overcooking.
- 2

Screaming hot wok, high smoke-point oil. Beef in a single layer — do NOT crowd the pan. Sear 90 seconds, then shake/toss. Add garlic, deglaze with the marinade, finish with butter. Serve on bed

of watercress and sliced red onion dressed with vinegar. Lime-pepper dipping salt on the side.

Menu Positioning: Bò Lúc Lắc is your premium item and table spend anchor. At \$19.99 it signals quality. The tableside presentation — sizzling beef on wilted watercress — creates visual and aromatic impact that neighbouring tables notice.

BEEF

SOY

GLUTEN (oyster sauce)

DAIRY (butter)

Cà Ri Gà — Vietnamese Chicken Curry

Coconut chicken curry with lemongrass and potato, bánh mì or jasmine rice · Sell: \$16.99

7 min service

Main

Target FC: 16%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Chicken thigh (bone-in, per portion)	200g	\$0.56
Coconut milk	120ml	\$0.28
Vietnamese curry powder + turmeric	8g	\$0.06
Lemongrass, shallot, garlic, chili	30g	\$0.12
Potato (cubed)	80g	\$0.08
Fish sauce + sugar	seasoning	\$0.04
Bánh mì or rice (for dipping/serving)	1 portion	\$0.45
Total cost		\$1.59

Cost per serve	\$1.59
Sell price	\$16.99
Food cost %	9.4%
Contribution margin	\$15.40

METHOD

- 1 Vietnamese curry is aromatic and mild by South Asian standards — the lemongrass dominates, coconut milk is rich but not cream-thick. Sauté lemongrass, shallot, garlic, curry powder in oil until fragrant. Add chicken thighs — brown well. Add coconut milk and water to cover, simmer 25 minutes. Add potato last (15 min before done).
- 2 Batch-cook this dish — a big pot made in the morning holds through the lunch service. Serve in a small clay pot or deep bowl, with bánh mì on the side for dipping. The bread-into-curry pairing is distinctively Vietnamese.

CHICKEN

COCONUT

FISH (fish sauce)

GLUTEN (bánh mì)

Mì Quảng — Quảng Nam Turmeric Noodles

Turmeric-stained wide noodles, shrimp, pork, peanuts, rice crackers, minimal broth · Sell: \$15.99

7 min

Main

Target FC: 14%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Turmeric rice noodles (wide flat)	1 portion	\$0.45
Shrimp (peeled)	60g	\$0.72
Pork shoulder (braised)	60g	\$0.24
Shrimp-pork topping broth (small amount)	80ml	\$0.16
Roasted peanuts, sesame	20g	\$0.14

Rice crackers (bánh trắng nướng)	2 pcs	\$0.12
Fresh herbs, banana flower shreds	30g	\$0.20
Total cost		\$2.03

Cost per serve	\$2.03
Sell price	\$15.99
Food cost %	12.7%
Contribution margin	\$13.96

METHOD

- 1 Mì Quảng is Central Vietnam's answer to pho — but it's barely a soup. Just enough broth to moisten the noodles. The topping broth is made from shrimp and pork simmered together, seasoned with annatto oil for colour, fish sauce for depth.
- 2 Build the bowl: turmeric noodles, shrimp, pork, pour over small ladle of hot broth. Top with peanuts, sesame. Serve with rice crackers on the side for crumbling in. Guests break the crackers into the bowl — a unique textural experience.

Menu Differentiator: Most Vietnamese restaurants in the US only offer pho and bun bo hue. Mì Quảng signals serious regional knowledge and attracts Vietnamese-American diners who grew up with it. It's a powerful community signal.

SHELLFISH PORK FISH (fish sauce) NUTS (peanuts)

3 Desserts

Chè Ba Màu — Three-Colour Dessert

Green mung bean jelly, red kidney beans, yellow mung bean paste, coconut milk, crushed ice · Sell: \$6.99

2 min assembly Dessert Target FC: ~14%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Green mung bean pandan jelly	40g	\$0.12
Red kidney beans (sweetened)	40g	\$0.10
Yellow mung bean paste (sweetened)	40g	\$0.12
Coconut cream	60ml	\$0.14
Crushed ice	generous	\$0.02
Pandan-simple syrup	20ml	\$0.02
Total cost		\$0.52

Cost per serve	\$0.52
Sell price	\$6.99
Food cost %	7.4%
Contribution margin	\$6.47

Visual Impact: Serve in a tall clear glass — the green, red, and yellow layers visible through the glass create an immediate social media moment. Pre-layer during service prep; add ice and coconut cream to order.

COCONUT

Bánh Flan — Vietnamese Crème Caramel

Silky egg custard, dark caramel, iced coffee drizzle · Sell: \$6.99

1 min plating Dessert Target FC: ~12%

INGREDIENTS (PER SERVING)

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Eggs (whole)	2 × 55g	\$0.70
Condensed milk	40ml	\$0.22
Whole milk	100ml	\$0.10
Sugar (for caramel)	20g	\$0.02
Vanilla extract	1ml	\$0.01
Total cost		\$1.05

Cost per serve	\$1.05
Sell price	\$6.99
Food cost %	15.0%
Contribution margin	\$5.94

Batch Bake: Bánh flan must be made the night before — steam in individual ramekins 25 minutes, cool, refrigerate. The condensed milk gives Vietnamese flan its distinctive richer, denser texture compared to French crème caramel. A drizzle of strong brewed Vietnamese coffee on plating is the signature touch.

EGGS DAIRY

Chè Chuối — Banana Coconut Pudding

Ripe banana, tapioca pearls, coconut milk, pandan, toasted sesame · Sell: \$5.99

2 min service Dessert Target FC: ~13%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Ripe banana (sliced)	1 medium	\$0.20
Coconut milk	120ml	\$0.28
Tapioca pearls (cooked)	30g	\$0.06
Sugar + pandan leaf	15g + 1 leaf	\$0.04
Toasted sesame seeds	5g	\$0.04
Total cost		\$0.62

Cost per serve	\$0.62
Sell price	\$5.99
Food cost %	10.3%
Contribution margin	\$5.37

Method: Simmer coconut milk with pandan leaf and sugar until fragrant. Add banana and tapioca pearls, cook 3 minutes until banana softens. Serve warm. A batch made fresh each morning holds well for 4 hours.

COCONUT SESAME

Sinh Tố Bơ — Avocado Smoothie

Avocado, condensed milk, crushed ice — a Vietnamese café staple · Sell: \$7.99

2 min blend

Dessert/Drink

Target FC: ~18%

INGREDIENTS

INGREDIENT	WEIGHT	COST
Ripe Hass avocado	1 medium	\$1.20
Condensed milk	30ml	\$0.16
Crushed ice	generous	\$0.02
Coconut milk (optional, richness)	30ml	\$0.07
Total cost		\$1.45

Cost per serve	\$1.45
Sell price	\$7.99
Food cost %	18.1%
Contribution margin	\$6.54

Blending: Blend avocado, condensed milk, and ice until thick and creamy. The result should be milkshake-thick — not a juice, not a smoothie — dense, rich, and pale green. Serve in a tall glass. At \$7.99 with a \$1.45 cost, this is one of your highest-margin single items.

DAIRY (condensed milk)

4

Drinks

Cà Phê Sữa Đá

\$5.99

Vietnamese iced coffee slow-dripped through aphin filter onto condensed milk. The ritual of watching it drip is part of the experience. At 60 cups/day, this is your highest-volume drink.

Food cost	\$0.72
Food cost %	12.0%
Contribution margin	\$5.27

DAIRY

CAFFEINE

Trà Đá — Iced Jasmine Tea

\$3.99

Traditional Vietnamese table tea — jasmine green tea over ice, slightly sweetened. In Vietnam this is free at most restaurants. Here it's a \$3.99 upsell that costs \$0.20. A high-volume, near-zero-cost item.

Food cost	\$0.20
Food cost %	5.0%
Contribution margin	\$3.79

Nước Mía — Sugarcane Juice

\$5.99

Fresh-pressed sugarcane juice with a squeeze of kumquat — the quintessential Vietnamese street drink. Press to order if you have a sugarcane press, or source from a vendor. The visual of sugarcane pressing in-house is a major draw.

Food cost	\$0.80
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Food cost %	13.4%
Contribution margin	\$5.19

Soda Chanh Muối

\$4.99

Salted preserved lemon soda — a uniquely Vietnamese flavour profile. The muối (salt-preserved limes) ferment for months and develop an umami-citrus depth. Mix with sparkling water and a touch of sugar syrup. Addictive and unusual to American palates.

Food cost	\$0.35
Food cost %	7.0%
Contribution margin	\$4.64

333 Beer (Ba Ba Ba)

\$6.99

Vietnam's most iconic beer — crisp, light, with a distinctive hop note. The perfect match for pho and bánh mì. "Ba ba ba" is what Vietnamese diners say to toast. Selling the story sells the beer.

Food cost	\$1.40
Food cost %	20.0%
Contribution margin	\$5.59

GLUTEN ALCOHOL

Sài Gòn Beer

\$6.99

Ho Chi Minh City's premium lager — slightly fuller body than 333, with a clean malt character. The recognisable red and gold label has strong brand recognition among Vietnamese-American diners.

Food cost	\$1.40
Food cost %	20.0%
Contribution margin	\$5.59

GLUTEN ALCOHOL

Rượu Đế Cocktail

\$11.99

House cocktail with Vietnamese rice spirit (rượu đế), lemongrass, lime, and a pinch of muối (salt). Clear, clean, and aromatic — positions your café as a serious food-and-drink destination at lunch.

Food cost	\$1.80
Food cost %	15.0%
Contribution margin	\$10.19

ALCOHOL

Smoothie Xoài — Mango Smoothie

\$6.99

Blended ripe Vietnamese mango (or frozen Ataulfo mango), condensed milk, and crushed ice. Thick, sweet, intensely fruity. A natural upsell alongside any lunch plate — particularly popular with families and younger diners.

Food cost	\$0.90
Food cost %	12.9%
Contribution margin	\$6.09

5 Kitchen Prep Flow

The Overnight Broth Protocol — Your competitive moat is a stockpot that runs while you sleep. While your competitors are making 4-hour shortcut broths at 5 AM, your 18-hour broth has been building flavour since yesterday evening. The difference is not effort — it is scheduling. Start the broth before you leave for the night. That is the entire secret.

Time	Head Cook	Line Cook	Steward / Prep
5:00 PM (Night Before)	Broth on. Blanch beef bones 10 min, drain, rinse. Char whole ginger and onion on gas flame until blackened. Bones + charred aromatics into stockpot, cold water to cover. Bring to bare simmer. Begin first skim. Spice packet goes in at hour 2. 18-hr simmer begins.	Make wonton filling (pork + shrimp + water chestnut + seasoning). Portion and freeze chả giò from batch supply. Marinate pork (ribs, belly, shoulder) overnight. Prep pork braise for Bún Bò Huế.	Wash and spin all herbs. Portion pickled daikon/carrot (đồ chua) into service containers. Clean and stock walk-in. Wash rice, set rice cooker timer for 5:30 AM.
6:30 AM	Skim broth, taste and season with fish sauce and rock sugar. Strain into service bain — hold at 85°C. Start chicken pho broth if needed. Season and taste all service broths.	Pull chả giò from freezer to fryer. Make wonton soup broth. Portion and prep chè chuối (banana coconut pudding) for the day. Rice on at station. Set up noodle blanching system.	Fill herb plates. Portion bean sprout plates. Slice limes and chili. Fill condiment stations (hoisin, sriracha, fish sauce, chili sauce). Stock phin filters and Vietnamese coffee.
7:00 AM (OPEN)	Pho station ready. Broth at service temp. Thin-slice eye round for tái — keep refrigerated at 4°C until each bowl. Taste broth one final time and adjust. All proteins at station.	Noodle blanching system set — rolling boil in noodle station. Spring roll assembly station prepped with moist towel, rice paper in water. Grill hot for bánh mì service.	Floors swept, tables set, water station ready. Phin filter setup on bar — first drips going for early Cà Phê Sữa Đá orders. Ice bin full.
9:00 AM	Second broth skim. Top up service bain. Check protein supply — project lunch demand. Slice bánh mì pork. Begin afternoon mis en place if needed.	Herb washing second batch. Bánh mì assembly line setup (pâté portioned, pickles restocked, cucumber sliced). Begin pork marination for tomorrow's service. Wonton filling second batch if running low.	Mid-morning clean of prep area. Re-stock condiment stations. Check ice. Prep dessert chè ba màu layers — portion into service glasses, refrigerate.
11:30 AM (Lunch Rush)	Lunch rush prep complete. Bò Lúc Lắc station ready — wok on, beef cubed and marinated. Cơm Tấm grill hot and clean. All broths at temp, all proteins sliced and ready. Expedite.	Grill hot and clean for Cơm Tấm ribs and bánh mì pork. Wok fire up for Bò Lúc Lắc and egg fried rice. Dessert chè portioned and refrigerated ready for service.	All tables clean and set. Herb plates topped up. Condiment stations checked. Water pitchers filled. Service team briefed on specials and 86 list.

6 Financial Model

Daily Revenue Projection — 26 Operating Days/Month

Period	Covers	Avg Spend	Daily Revenue
Breakfast (7:00am – 11:00am)	38	\$28	\$1,064
Lunch (11:00am – 3:00pm)	56	\$42	\$2,352

Daily Total	94 covers	\$36 blended	\$3,416
Monthly Revenue (26 days)			\$88,816

Monthly P&L

Line Item	Amount	% of Revenue
Gross Revenue	\$88,816	100%
Food Cost (21%)	−\$18,651	21%
Labour	−\$17,200	19.4%
Rent	−\$5,800	6.5%
Other (utilities, supplies, marketing)	−\$5,000	5.6%
Net Operating Profit	\$42,165	47.5%

Ramp-Up Projection

Month	Capacity Fill	Approx. Revenue	Estimated Net
Month 1 (opening)	55%	~\$48,800	~\$8,500
Month 2	75%	~\$66,600	~\$23,000
Month 3 (stabilised)	100%	\$88,816	\$42,165

US Market Ingredient Reference Prices: Beef brisket \$6/lb · Beef bones \$2.50/lb · Eye round \$8/lb · Chicken \$2.80/lb · Pork shoulder \$4/lb · Pork belly \$4.50/lb · Pork ribs \$5/lb · Rice vermicelli \$1.80/lb · Pho noodles \$0.45/portion · Bánh mì baguette \$0.45 each · Fish sauce \$3/qt · Bean sprouts \$1.50/lb · Fresh herbs \$4/lb · Vietnamese coffee \$12/lb · Condensed milk \$2/14oz can · Avocado \$1.20 each

7 Service Training Scripts

Train every front-of-house team member to deliver these scripts naturally. The goal is confident storytelling, not recitation. These scripts transform table service into cultural education — and cultural education creates loyal regulars.

SCRIPT 1 — THE PHO ASSEMBLY EXPLANATION

"Your pho arrives with a side plate of fresh herbs, bean sprouts, and lime — these are yours to add as you go. The basil goes in the broth and wilts slightly; the sprouts give crunch; the lime brightens the whole bowl. There's hoisin for dipping your beef, and sriracha if you'd like heat. The broth is meant to be very hot — take a moment before you dig in, or the beef cooks more as it sits. That's actually part of the experience."

SCRIPT 2 — THE BROTH STORY (18 HOURS)

"Our pho broth starts every evening at 5 PM — it simmers overnight for 18 hours before it reaches your bowl. We char the ginger and onion directly on the flame — you'll see them get black on the outside — that char is what gives the broth its deep, smoky sweetness. The spice packet goes in only after the beef foundation is built: star anise, cinnamon, cloves, cardamom. You can smell all of them in the bowl. It's not a quick thing to make. That's why it tastes this way."

SCRIPT 3 — THE BÁNH MÌ DESCRIPTION (FRENCH COLONIAL HISTORY)

"Bánh mì is one of the most interesting food stories in the world. The baguette came to Vietnam with the French in the 19th century — but Vietnamese bakers remade it lighter, crispier, partly with rice flour. Then the fillings became entirely Vietnamese: pork pâté, pickled daikon and carrot, fresh herbs, and Maggi seasoning. It's a French vessel with a Vietnamese soul. What you're eating is the product of 150 years of culinary colonisation, adaptation, and reinvention. We think it turned out well."

SCRIPT 4 — THE CÀ PHÊ SỮA ĐÁ RITUAL

"Vietnamese coffee is made through a phin filter — that small metal drip press sitting on top of your glass. The grounds are pressed with a filter plate, and the coffee drips slowly — about 4 to 5 minutes — straight onto the condensed milk at the bottom. When it's done dripping, you stir it together and pour it over the ice. The condensed milk was used because fresh milk was scarce during the French colonial period — and it turned out to taste better. You'll understand when you taste it."

SCRIPT 5 — THE CHÈ BA MÀU PRE-SELL

"For dessert — can I tell you about our chè ba màu? It's a Vietnamese three-colour dessert served in a tall glass — you can see the green pandan jelly, red kidney beans, and yellow mung bean paste in layers before it's topped with coconut cream and crushed ice. It's sweet, cold, and light — nothing like a Western dessert. The colours represent the three regions of Vietnam. It photographs beautifully if that matters to you. Most people who try it order it again on their next visit."

45-Minute Table Timing Guide

Vietnamese pho and bánh mì service should feel relaxed and generous. The 45-minute window maximises table turns without making guests feel rushed. Follow this rhythm.

Time	Action	Detail
0:00	Seat and greet	Menus presented. Vietnamese iced tea offered immediately — "Our house trà đá, on the table for you." Sets a welcoming, generous tone before the order is taken.
3:00	Drinks order + food order	Take both together where possible. Describe the Cà Phê Sữa Đá to first-timers ("it drips while you eat — arrives before your food is done"). Upsell a spring roll starter.
7:00	Drinks delivered	Phin filter set up at the table with explanation (Script 4). Starters en route from kitchen. Confirm any allergies now if not already done at ordering.
10:00	Starters on table	Quick description of herb plate (spring rolls) or dipping sauce. Return within 90 seconds: "Is everything how you like it?"
18:00	Main courses on table	Deliver pho with broth story (Script 2) — one sentence is enough. Remind guest the side plate is theirs to add at their own pace. Check back within 2 minutes.
22:00	2-minute check	"How's the broth?" — invites engagement and identifies any issues early. Pre-sell dessert at this point: "Have you had chè ba màu before?" (Script 5).
32:00	Clear mains, dessert order	Clear plates when 80%+ complete. Take dessert order confidently. "The bánh flan takes 30 seconds to plate — I'll grab one for you now." Confidence in the upsell matters.
38:00	Dessert on table	Deliver with one-line description. Offer a second coffee — "Another Cà Phê Sữa Đá? It's our most reordered drink." This is often said yes to.
45:00	Bill presented	Bring bill unprompted. Thank the table. If regulars: "See you next week" is better than "Come back soon." Personal recognition creates loyalty faster than any loyalty program.

8 Customer Retention & VIP Micro-Moments

Vietnamese café culture is built on ritual and regularity. Guests who come once for pho come back for the broth. Your job is to create five micro-moments that make the second visit inevitable.

Micro-Moment 1 — The Broth Compliment Protocol

When a guest finishes their pho bowl and doesn't leave broth behind, they loved it. This is your cue: "You finished the whole broth — that's the best compliment our head cook gets all day. She'll be pleased." This single sentence creates a human connection between the guest and your kitchen. It also signals to the guest that they have a relationship with the establishment — not just a transaction. Regulars who feel this connection return weekly.

☞ **Micro-Moment 2 — The Phin Filter Education**

When a guest receives their Cà Phê Sữa Đá and watches the drip, don't rush them. Say: "You don't need to wait for it to finish dripping before your food — it'll be ready by the time you need it." Then walk away. Let the ritual breathe. Guests who understand the phin filter become evangelists — they tell friends about it, they post about it, and they return specifically to experience it again. This drink alone drives a significant share of social media content for Vietnamese cafés.

Micro-Moment 3 — The Herb Plate Refill Offer

Mid-way through a pho bowl, notice if the herb plate is empty. Offer unprompted: "Would you like more herbs and sprouts? We keep them in the kitchen." The cost is near zero (\$0.10 of herbs). The perceived generosity is enormous. Guests remember being offered more rather than being ignored. This micro-moment costs nothing and creates disproportionate goodwill — especially with Vietnamese-American diners who know this is authentic café hospitality.

Micro-Moment 4 — The Bánh Mì First-Timer Script

When a guest orders bánh mì for the first time (you can usually tell), deliver it with: "This is the Vietnamese baguette — lighter and crispier than French bread. The pickled daikon and carrot are house-made. If you want more jalapeño, just ask — no charge." First-timers who feel guided become regulars. They return because they feel ownership over the experience — they know the story, they know how to order it their way. That familiarity is the foundation of a regular customer.

Micro-Moment 5 — The Recognition Return

By a guest's third visit, your team should know their name or their order. "The usual pho bò tái?" is worth more than any loyalty stamp card. Train your team to remember one detail about each regular: their name, their heat preference, whether they take condensed milk in their coffee. Verbal recognition is the highest form of hospitality in any culture. In Vietnamese café culture — where the neighbourhood pho shop has known families for generations — it is expected. Meet that expectation, even as a new business.

Best Social Media Post — The Broth Pour Video

The Broth Pour Video — Your Best Performing Content Type

Shoot this: Overhead camera on a pho bowl assembly. Noodles in the bowl, raw eye-round beef slices fanned on top. Then: ladle of steaming, golden, clear broth poured slowly from height — the steam rises, the beef begins to turn at the edges. Cut to: fresh herbs being added, lime squeezed, chopsticks lifting noodles.

Caption formula:

"18 hours. Right there in your bowl. The broth started yesterday at 5 PM — charred ginger, charred onion, star anise, cinnamon, bones. This morning we strained it. This is what happens when it hits the beef. [Location tag] [Vietnamese flag emoji]"

Why it works: The steam-and-sizzle moment is inherently satisfying to watch. The 18-hour context adds perceived value. The raw beef cooking in the bowl in real-time is surprising to first-time viewers. This post format — when shot cleanly — routinely generates 50,000+ organic views for Vietnamese restaurants with under 2,000 followers. Post Tuesday–Thursday between 11:30 AM and 1:00 PM for maximum lunch-hour reach.